

THE NUMBERS GAME

Websites are only effective if they're attracting the right visitors. Web analytics helps you know them better

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Customers are the lifeblood of any business. For businesses that depend on Web visibility for their growth, customers mean visitors on their Web sites—those who come once should be interested, and visit more often. Whether you're a business Web site, blog, forum, hobbyist site or news site—any site that earns money, in fact—you should care about visitors. And before caring about them, you must know about them, where they come from, and what they want. This, and a variety of other answers, can come from the wonderful art of Web analytics.

Why Analyse?

As you might have already guessed, Web analytics means number-crunching. It means using tools to collect data on the server side, and then analysing that data to understand where you, as an investor, are getting your expected ROI (Return On Investment). At the more basic level, the data will let you know whether you have succeeded in reaching out to your intended audience.

Consider this: you're running a business selling diapers, and it's not a brick-and-mortar business in that you have no outlets—just the Web site. Being a new business, you don't have a widespread distribution network and for now aim to cater to local needs. As a businessperson, you are necessarily interested in how many people are visiting your online shop. You run a Web analysis where you find that there is only a minority of your visitors come from your city, or neighbouring areas. And what's worse, there are very few who click on the cart and make a purchase, which in Web analytics

jargon is called *goal conversion*. Your business is obviously not becoming profitable, and you need to do something about it. With Web analytics, you get to know about this in advance and hopefully do something before the bills start arriving and the creditors start queuing outside your doors. Without Web Analytics, you would be in for a rude shock.

(Don't) Bluff Your Way Through

And now, time for the customary round of jargon-busting. Web analytics being a subject which uses maths, most of these terms describe percentages and numbers which most tools use:

Hits: This is one of the most widely used terms when any talk regarding the popularity, or otherwise of a Website comes up. However, it is also the most widely misused. While hits in general parlance means the number of visitors, the technical definition of hits is any request for a file from a file server. For example, if a page has three images and there are requests for them, this is considered as three hits. Depending on the page elements like CSS and JavaScript, a single viewer can generate multiple hits, so remember that this figure is never as high as it seems.

Page views: This is what people mean when they are talking about hits. A page view is the successful loading of a document on a server, and doesn't include visits by search robots or error messages, requests for sound and video files, or even CSS and images. Page views don't denote the number of people visiting the site, because a single visitor can visit multiple pages and request a number of documents.

User Sessions: This is the metric used for determining the number of visitors that actually spend time on your site—it is usually recorded for 30 minutes of users' activity. It accounts for both IP addresses, and the number of users logged in, if applicable. User sessions are great for understanding the behaviour of viewers, as data about which links the viewer visited and how much time the visitor has spent on each link. This raises a few problems, for example the activity of the users who might have remained inactive for 30 minutes and then started clicking would be neglected. Like Hits, this metric should not be taken at face value either.

Unique visitors: This metric determines the number of persons who has visited the Website within a definite interval of time. Unique visitors are determined by the combination of user agent (usually browsers, though other programs like search engine spiders and screen readers are included) and IP address. The time interval can be a day or a week or a month—it depends on the type of Website. So if the time interval is one week and a visitor visits it twice in two consecutive days, it would be counted as one visit.

Bounce rate: This is a metric which indicates the percentage of visitors who have left immediately after visiting the site—usually five seconds. For a site with multiple pages, bounce



How well you know what your users are looking for, and how quickly you can act on it—is one of the most important parameters that contributes to any online portal's success

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rate can also be measured as the percentage of people who visit only one page, or do not click on any links; this definition depends on the tool you are using. If the number is high, it means that something is seriously wrong with your site, and you need to fix it. For most Web sites, bounce rates between 20 and 35 per cent are acceptable, and rates higher than 50 per cent are worrisome. However, in case of blogs, high bounce rates may not indicate that something is rotten—most people visit a blog to read a single post, or check if there are updates.

Conversion: This is a complex metric which indicates how many visitors to your Web site did what you wanted them to do. Consider a Web site that has a Donate button, Register link or shopping cart. You want your readers to click on these types of links, which are called Goals in analyticspeak. When a reader clicks on such goals, that's considered a conversion. High conversion rates (the percentage of visitors that actually click on the goals) indicate that all's well. If this percentage disappoints, then it's back to the drawing board. However conversion rate is entirely user determined, depending on the goals.

Traffic sources: Traffic sources are the places from which visitors come to a site. Tools usually divide traffic sources for a Web site into four types—direct traffic (by keying in URLs), referring sites (other sites which have link to

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